SOUTH AFRICA

JANUARY 2015 – JULY 2026

Prepared by Africa INSIGHTS Research Team | Vertical: Travel & Tourism

South Africa's perception score has dropped sharply in 2026, driven by worsening cost, transport and hospitality sentiment that now outweighs its enduring scenery strength.

2,164	59%	20%	20%	65/100
RECORDS IN VIEW	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	PERCEPTION

01 MONTH IN REVIEW

South Africa's travel perception has deteriorated meaningfully across the full reporting window, and the deterioration has accelerated sharply in the most recent year on record. The overall perception score across the period stands at **65 out of 100**, with a net sentiment of **38.9** — figures that mask the severity of the 2026 slide to a score of **52**, the lowest point in the entire dataset. The primary drivers of that decline are cost, transport, and hospitality, all of which have worsened significantly in the second half of the period; safety, despite a slight structural improvement, remains the single most negative theme in the dataset and the most damaging gap relative to peers.

The destination's natural assets — scenery and wildlife — remain genuinely loved and continue to anchor positive perception, but they are no longer sufficient to offset mounting service and infrastructure complaints. With **35.7%** of 2026 records carrying negative sentiment against just **11.5%** in 2015, the gap between what the landscape promises and what the visitor experience delivers has become the central perception problem.

The single most urgent action is to address the safety narrative directly and visibly. Safety carries the worst net sentiment of any theme at **-38.5** and a **47-point gap** behind the peer average — a gap that no amount of scenery content can bridge. A targeted safety communications strategy, coordinated with operators at high-traffic destinations and visible in all outbound marketing, should be the board's immediate priority.

DATA NOTE

The 2026 data covers January to July only, meaning the year-to-date figure is based on a partial year. The sharp drop in the 2026 perception score should be interpreted with that in mind, though the volume of records (420) is the highest of any single year in the dataset and the finding is directionally robust.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

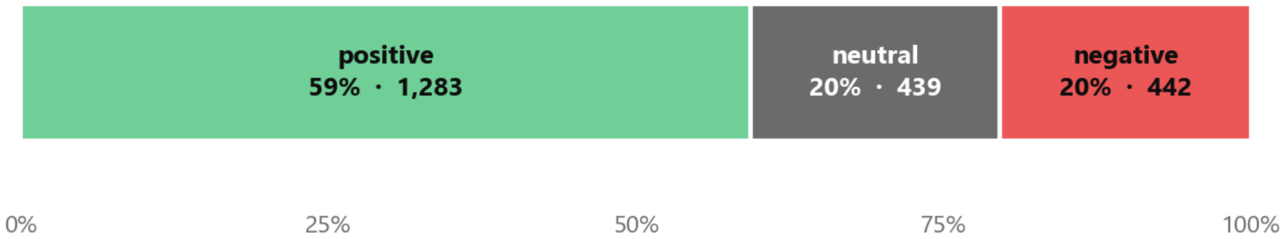
Across the full period, South Africa registers a perception score of **65 on the 0–100 scale**, placing it above the neutral midpoint of 50 but short of strong-positive territory. The net sentiment of **38.9** reflects a broadly positive but structurally fragile market position: **59.3%** of records are positive, **20.3%** neutral, and **20.4%** negative. The near-symmetry between the neutral and negative shares is telling — a significant portion of the audience is not won over, and the negative cohort is large enough to dent the destination's reputation in peer-to-peer channels.

The positive share, while the majority, is lower than every peer country in the upper tier of the benchmark. The **20.4%** negative rate compounds that disadvantage: it is the second-highest in the reportable peer group, exceeded only by Morocco. For a destination that commands significant marketing investment and global name recognition, these figures suggest that word-of-mouth is underperforming relative to brand reach. The implication is that visitors who arrive with high expectations, shaped by marketing of scenery and wildlife, are encountering service and safety realities that generate disproportionate negative commentary.

The emotional texture of the dataset reinforces this reading. **28.1%** of records carry an excited emotion — the strongest single emotion — while fearful accounts for **3.7%** and disappointed for **1.8%**. Excitement remains the dominant register, which means the destination's aspirational appeal is intact. The task is converting that excitement at the awareness stage into satisfaction at the experience stage.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown

How the 2,164 records in view split across sentiment classes. Net sentiment is +39 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is the clearest positive in the dataset and the most mentioned theme by a substantial margin, with **609 mentions** and a net sentiment of **66.5**. At **78.5%** positive, it functions as South Africa's reputational foundation and the primary driver of excited emotion across the corpus. Wildlife is also a genuine draw, reflected in **174 mentions** and a positive share of **59.2%**; the voice of @marcelkohler3016 (May 2021), expressing emotional connection to rhino conservation efforts, captures the depth of feeling that wildlife experiences generate — an asset that extends well beyond passive sightseeing into advocacy and loyalty. Food rounds out the positive cluster with a net sentiment of **44.4** across **124 mentions**, suggesting that culinary experiences are a consistent source of satisfaction and an underutilised messaging asset.

Safety is the dominant negative theme and the most analytically urgent. With **135 mentions**, a negative share of **65.2%**, and a net sentiment of **-38.5**, it is not a marginal concern — it is the theme most likely to suppress conversion from consideration to booking. The perception of a stark socioeconomic divide, captured powerfully by @ashleynesh1 (Apr 2021) — *"the divide between the poor and rich is stark, it's gigantic"* — with an engagement of **46,332**, reflects the way safety and inequality concerns are intertwined in international discourse about the country. No other voice in the dataset approaches that level of engagement, making it the single most influential piece of content and a direct risk to destination image. Cost is the second most negative theme, with a net sentiment of **-18.4** across **49 mentions** and a negative share of **49.0%** — a significant reversal from earlier in the period when cost was a relative strength.

Hospitality is the theme that most directly connects the natural asset base to the visitor experience, and it is underperforming. With **228 mentions** — the third-highest volume of any theme — a negative share of **42.5%**, and a net sentiment of just **3.5**, hospitality is effectively neutral in aggregate while trending negative. Transport sits at a similar structural position: **157 mentions**, a positive share of **47.8%**, and a net of **17.2** that, while above zero, has been deteriorating. Electricity, with a net of **-26.7** and a negative share of **60.0%**, is the second-worst performing theme and one that feeds directly into hospitality and cost complaints — load-shedding and infrastructure instability surface across multiple adjacent themes even when not explicitly labelled.

> **DATA NOTE**
> The electricity theme clears the 15-mention threshold for reportability on the aspect score but its movement data does not meet the reportable threshold (fewer than 50 mentions in first half), so trend claims on electricity are excluded from this section.

> **DATA NOTE**
> Voices are drawn predominantly from YouTube comments (86.7% of total records). The engagement metrics reflect platform amplification and may not be representative of the broader travelling public's views.

Voices behind the numbers

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions in this view. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

POSITIVE · @KimmyVG2323 · Apr 2021 · 4,466 likes · score +0.31
“As a South African I can say that the divide between the rich and poor is still as great as before. As an Indian whose parents grew up in very poor neighbourhoods I am very fortunate to have the life that I have but while a few managed to have a “new” life after apartheid most have not changed”

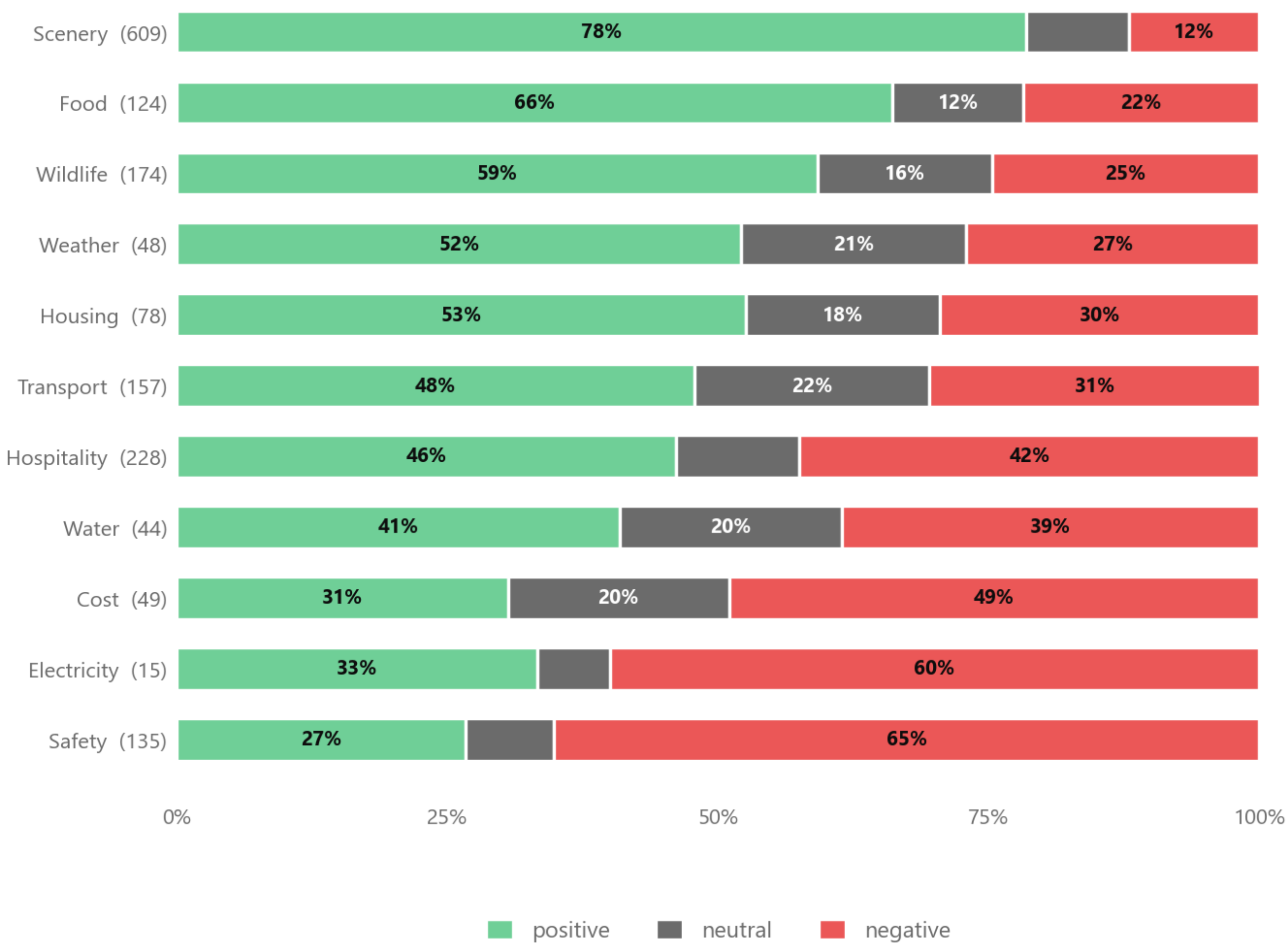
POSITIVE · @marcelkohler3016 · May 2021 · 2,857 likes · score +0.86
“I’m a South African and it made me very emotional to see that they want to help save a Rhino on their bucket list. Go Dude Perfect!”

NEGATIVE · @ashleynesh1 · Apr 2021 · 46,332 likes · score -0.75
“As a South African I can tell you that the divide between the poor and rich is stark, it's gigantic”

NEGATIVE · @bobbyshabangu · Dec 2018 · 35,144 likes · score -0.45
“Some people are critising Trevor for not buying her grandmother a house and new furniture. Just to let you know, if you read Trevor's book Born a Crime, Trevor explains that gogo doesn't want her furniture refurbished and certainly she doesn't want to be moved. And that applies to all our South Afr…”

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

Only the adventure segment clears the minimum sample threshold of 50 records and can therefore be assessed with analytical confidence. Adventure travellers represent **10.0%** of classified records, with a perception score of **67** and a net sentiment of **45.8** — both above the country-level averages of 65 and 38.9 respectively. Their positive share of **62.5%** and negative share of **16.7%** indicate that this cohort experiences South Africa more favourably than the general population of reviewers, which aligns with their orientation toward natural environments and outdoor activities — the very themes where South Africa performs best.

The practical implication is that adventure-focused product — safari, hiking, coastal and wildlife experiences — is currently South Africa's highest-converting segment in perception terms. The marketing mix should weight adventure narratives heavily in markets where this segment indexes strongly, and operators in this space should be prioritised for service quality investment to protect the segment's above-average scores. Equally, the segment's lower negative share suggests that adventure travellers are less exposed to, or more tolerant of, the infrastructure and safety frictions that drag on the country-level figures.

The budget, business, and luxury cohorts cannot be assessed at current sample sizes and are excluded from comparative analysis. This is a material gap: if budget travellers are disproportionately exposed to cost and safety concerns, and luxury travellers are less so, the segment-level picture would be substantially different from the aggregate, with direct implications for pricing and positioning strategy.

DATA NOTE
Only the adventure cohort meets the 50-record minimum threshold. Budget (33 records), business (30 records), and luxury (23 records) cohorts are all below threshold and cannot be compared against each other or the adventure segment. Their scores are noted in the data but cannot anchor findings or recommendations.

DATA NOTE
Only 14.0% of total records have been classified into a visitor segment, meaning 1,862 records carry no segment label. Segment-level findings should be treated as directional until classification coverage improves.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF VIEW	PERCEPTION	NET
Adventure	216	10.0%	67/100	+46
Budget · thin	33	1.5%	42/100	-24
Business · thin	30	1.4%	53/100	+13
Luxury · thin	23	1.1%	61/100	+30

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

South Africa ranks **7th out of 10** reportable peers on perception score, at **65** against the group leader Tanzania's **73** — a gap of **8 points**. The country sits above Egypt (**64**), Nigeria (**62**), and Morocco (**39**), but trails Tanzania, Ghana, Rwanda, Senegal, Kenya, and Zimbabwe — all of which post perception scores of 68 or above. South Africa's net sentiment of **38.9** is notably lower than the cluster of mid-tier peers: Kenya sits at **52.1**, Rwanda at **54.3**, and even Zimbabwe, a country with significant economic headwinds in its own right, posts a net sentiment of **50.5**. The implication is that South Africa's global profile attracts a higher volume of mixed or critical commentary than comparable destinations, even when its natural offering is objectively competitive.

The sharpest competitive disadvantage is in safety, where South Africa's net sentiment of **-38.5** trails the peer average by **47 points** — the largest reportable gap in the dataset. No other theme comes close to this magnitude of underperformance. On hospitality, a **24.2-point gap behind peers** represents the second-largest negative differential and is particularly damaging because hospitality is the high-volume interface between the destination's natural assets and the visitor's actual experience. On scenery, South Africa trails peers by **10.8 points** in net sentiment, which is notable given that scenery is the country's most-mentioned theme and its strongest card; closing this gap would require improving the consistency of scenic experience delivery, not just its visibility in marketing.

South Africa holds one clear competitive advantage: transport, where its net sentiment of **17.2** sits **20.4 points ahead** of the peer average of **-3.2**. This is a genuine differentiator and one that is rarely foregrounded in destination marketing — the relative accessibility and navigability of South Africa's road network and airport infrastructure appears to be valued by visitors in ways that set it apart from the regional peer group. On electricity, South Africa trails peers by **16.1 points** in net sentiment, consistent with the load-shedding issues that have featured prominently in domestic and international media across the period.

DATA NOTE
Cameroon does not meet the 50-record threshold (16 records) and is excluded from all comparative analysis.

DATA NOTE
The peer group benchmark figures represent averages across the reportable peer set; individual peer compositions and the specific markets they attract may differ from South Africa's, which limits the precision of like-for-like comparisons.

DATA NOTE
Housing, wildlife, food, cost, weather, and water aspect gaps do not meet the 10-point gap threshold and are therefore not discussed in this section.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50
Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

06 TRENDS & SIGNALS

The most significant trend in the dataset is the sharp decline in perception score in 2026. After holding in the 65–73 range for the decade from 2015 to 2025, the score has fallen to **52** in the partial year to July 2026 — a **18-point decline** from the period opening score of **70** in 2015, and a drop of **18 points** from the first to last period recorded. Alongside this, the negative sentiment share has risen from **11.5%** in 2015 to **35.7%** in 2026, with 2026 carrying the highest volume of records of any year in the dataset at **420**. The combination of high volume and elevated negativity makes this a signal, not drift.

At the theme level, cost is the fastest-deteriorating aspect, with negative sentiment rising by **33.5 points** between the first and second halves of the period — from **27.8%** negative to **61.3%** negative. Transport has worsened by **22.8 points**, wildlife by **19.8 points**, and housing by **15.4 points**. Food and hospitality have both worsened by more than 10 points. Taken together, these movements indicate a broad-based deterioration in the service and infrastructure experience, not a single-event shock. The only theme showing improvement is safety, where negative sentiment has declined by **6.6 points** — a modest but directionally meaningful shift that suggests anti-crime initiatives or improved communication around safety measures may be gaining some traction.

The peak years for positive perception were 2019 and 2023, both scoring **73** — matching Tanzania's current benchmark-leading score. That the destination has twice reached that level demonstrates that its ceiling is competitive; the question is what structural conditions enabled those peaks and whether they can be recreated. The 2019 peak preceded the pandemic disruption; the 2023 peak coincided with post-pandemic recovery enthusiasm and a period of lower recorded negativity. The 2024–2025 plateau at **70** was encouraging but was not sustained, and 2026's partial-year reading indicates that the platform did not hold.

DATA NOTE
The 2026 data covers January to July only. The perception score of 52 and negative share of 35.7% for 2026 represent a partial year and may shift as the year completes. However, the record volume of 420 gives this reading statistical weight.

DATA NOTE

The electricity aspect movement data does not meet the reportable threshold for trend analysis (fewer than 50 mentions in the first half), so the worsening direction noted in the data is flagged as indicative only and does not headline a trend finding.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)

Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

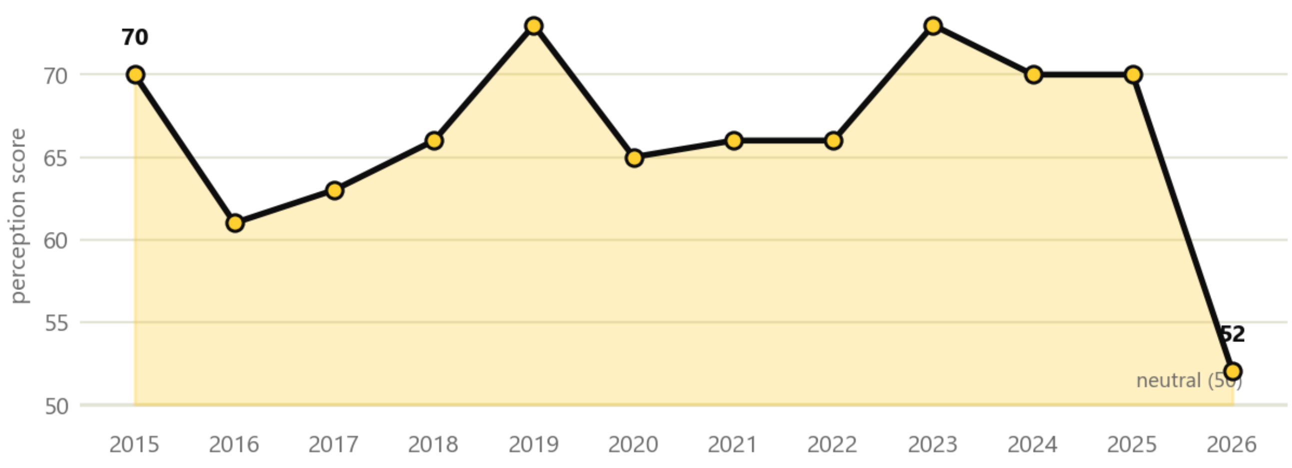
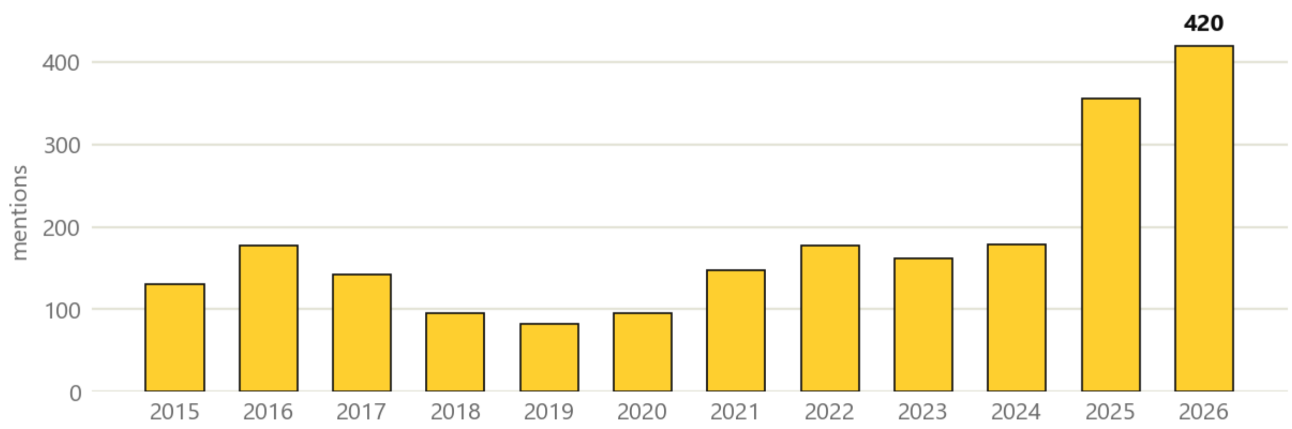


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)

Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The safety gap — a net sentiment of **-38.5** and a **47-point deficit against peers** — is the single finding that most urgently demands a response. The recommendation is to develop a dedicated safety narrative for outbound markets, co-authored with leading operators at high-traffic destinations such as Cape Town, Johannesburg, and the major safari corridors, and to feature visible safety infrastructure in campaign creative. This is not a generic call for better PR: the most-engaged piece of content in the dataset, @ashleynesh1's comment reaching **46,332** engagements, frames South Africa's inequality and safety concerns in terms that travel-intenders will encounter organically. Leaving that narrative uncontested is a strategic error. The primary audience is prospective visitors in conversion-stage marketing and travel trade intermediaries who brief clients on destination risk.

The cost deterioration — negative sentiment rising **33.5 points** across the period, now at **61.3%** negative in the second half — is damaging the value perception that historically made South Africa competitive relative to European and North American long-haul alternatives. The board should work with trade partners to reframe value in terms of experience depth per rand or per dollar, rather than defending a low-cost positioning that the market no longer perceives as accurate. Adventure travellers, the only segment with a reportable perception score of **67** and a net sentiment of **45.8**, are the most cost-resilient cohort and should anchor the near-term value narrative: their willingness to pay for authentic wildlife and landscape experiences is demonstrably higher than the general audience's.

Transport is a competitive advantage that is being eroded and is currently underused. With a net sentiment of **17.2** and a **20.4-point lead over the peer average**, South Africa's road infrastructure and aviation connectivity are genuine differentiators in the African travel context — and almost entirely absent from destination marketing. The board should brief its agency to incorporate transport ease and self-drive flexibility into campaign messaging targeted at the independent travel and adventure segments, where logistical confidence is a conversion factor. Simultaneously, the worsening transport trend — negative sentiment up **22.8 points** — means this advantage has a shelf life; the board should engage the transport ministry and major carriers with the deterioration data before the advantage disappears.

Hospitality requires structural rather than cosmetic intervention. With a net of **3.5** across **228 mentions**, a **24.2-point gap behind peers**, and a worsening trend of **11.0 points**, the hospitality experience is actively undermining the scenery and wildlife strengths that bring visitors to the country. The recommendation is to institute a perception feedback loop with hospitality operators — lodges, hotels, and guesthouses — using the theme-level data from this report as a baseline, and to tie Tourism Board partnership or co-funding criteria to measurable improvement in guest satisfaction indicators. The audience is hospitality operators in the mid-to-upper tier where the gap is most visible and where the brand investment in marketing is highest.

DATA NOTE
Budget, business, and luxury segment scores do not meet the minimum sample threshold and are not referenced in recommendations. Segment-specific recommendations beyond adventure travellers await improved classification coverage.

DATA NOTE
The electricity finding (net -26.7, 60.0% negative) is analytically significant but based on only 15 mentions at the aspect level. The recommendation to engage infrastructure stakeholders is supportable directionally, but the board should commission primary research specifically on load-shedding impact before making it a campaign commitment.

08 METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	South Africa
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all
Relevant records only	yes
Period	January 2015 – July 2026
Records	2,164
Generated	19 Aug 2026 12:35 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; every figure verified against the computed data.

Evidence base: 1,876 YouTube comments, 245 YouTube transcript segments, 43 Google Hotels reviews. 89% of records were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.